

Handheld Gaming is Back baby!

As a child, I was a huge fan of Nintendo's handheld consoles. Unfortunately, I never actually owned any of them. That didn't stop me though, there were means to play those games. As a child whose parents weren't too keen on spending money on anything to do with gaming, I found a way or two. That being said, I've spent hundreds of hours playing Gameboy games, Gameboy Advance games, and Nintendo DS games. Everytime I booted one of these games up on my PC, I would think to myself how awesome it would be if I could take these games with me, and play them while I was on the go. I could show them off to my friends, "look how I've gotten!", or "have you caught this pokemon yet?". You get the idea. Unfortunately, it was never meant to be. Sure, today you can play a bunch of games on your smartphones while on the go, but it's just not the same. Smartphone games simply don't have the same charm, most of them feel like interactive ads, and the few good ones leave your phone feeling like a furnace.

Also, it seemed like the era of handheld games was coming to an end. After the PS Vita, it seemed like all the mainstream consoles were aiming for bigger screens, higher resolutions, hyper-realistic graphics and bigger and more powerful hardware. There's no way things were going back to our hands. Then, the Nintendo Switch happened. Sure it was weaker than the other mainstream consoles but who cared? The hardware was powerful enough to play

Nintendo's beautifully crafted games while on the go, and then you could dock it and play on the large screen at home. It was literally the best of both worlds. Clearly, Nintendo were on to something, seeing how popular the console is.

That brings us to now, since the Switch, we've now seen two powerful mainstream handhelds. Valve's Steam Deck, and the very recent ASUS ROG Ally. The Steam Deck is essentially a handheld gaming PC. I don't know how, but Valve has done a great job with it, it plays tons of games really well. Even intensive games like God of War have been seen running smoothly on the Steam Deck, which, props to Valve, is an incredible achievement. This thing has a lot of the same functionalities as the Switch, such as being able to dock with a TV, but it can do even more. You can run a variety of apps on the Deck, not just games. Plus, you can stream games too, another thing the Switch can't do. Like I said, this is handheld gaming PC.

Now I don't know much about the ROG Ally, but it's supposedly even better than the Steam Deck. I haven't really seen it in action yet, but I can't say I don't dislike the direction things are going in. Even powerful gaming laptops have become a lot more portable of late, without needing two massive power bricks to run games. Sure, I don't mind carrying a 3 kg laptop around to play AAA games on ultra settings, but being able to carry a full-blown gaming PC without possible future back pain issues is a win in my books. *



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